and inexperienced athlete like me hope to compete with top international stars? Though this hurdle seemed insurmountable, it made me more determined to prove myself.

At the Village I met several foreign sportspeople, including Charles Jenkins, America's top athlete who had won the gold medal for the 400-metre event at Melbourne. Jenkins was a great hero of mine and when I heard that he was occupying the room next door, I was determined to meet him. Although I had received very basic English lessons from an Anglo-Indian nurse in Secunderabad, I was not very fluent in it, so enlisted my roommate Mohinder Singh's help. Jenkins was in the midst of an interview when we entered his room and invited us to return the next day. When we finally met him, Mohinder introduced me in his broken English saying: 'Milkha Singh from India, 400 metres, timing 48 seconds'. He further requested him to advise me on how to improve my timing. Jenkins kindly wrote down his complete training schedule for me to follow and from what he had indicated, a runner could only improve his timing and technique through regular and rigorous practice. His kind gesture inspired me and strengthened my desire to excel.

I soon saw how celebrated athletes were and the adulation that was showered on them almost amounted to hero worship. Sardars with their turbans attracted a lot of attention and there were always huge crowds of people outside the Village waiting to meet us, some insisting that we visit their homes, while others wanted autographs. I could not understand why small books and pens were thrust before me, and asked Mohinder what I should do. He said, just sign your name—that's an autograph—and so I did, many times over. When we would get back to our room we would compare notes and ask each other, '*Tu kinne sign kitte* ? (How many did you sign?)' That's how innocent and naïve we were.

Once the Games ended, we were given a few days off. After I had been eliminated from the event, an Australian family called Smith had befriended me. One evening, they invited Mohinder Singh, and me to their home for dinner, but it was only when we reached their house and saw them bringing out the food that we realized what being 'invited for dinner' meant. We had both had our meal at the Village, but didn't know how to communicate this to them. Mohinder tried to tell them in his broken English, or with gestures like rubbing his stomach to indicate we had eaten, but to no avail, and we were forced to have a second meal. After dinner was over, the two